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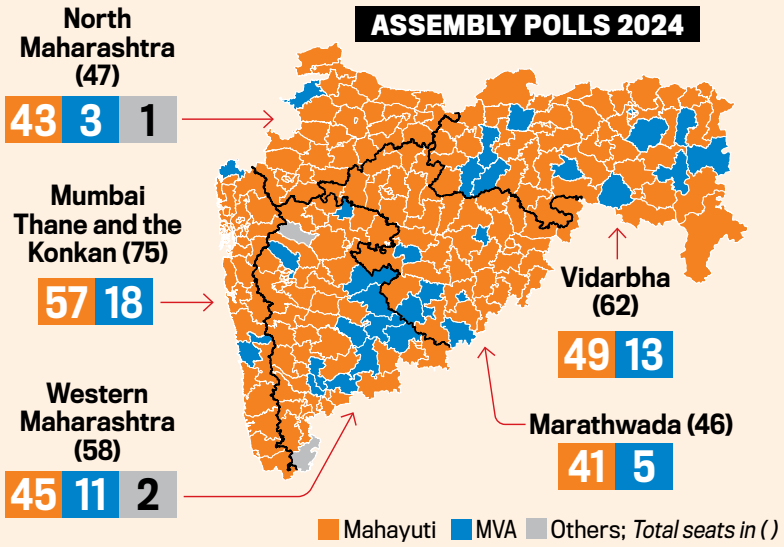


CHALLENGES FOR UDDHAV AND SHARAD

- Keeping their own flock together
- Maintain their core voter base, which in Uddhav's case overlaps with the BJP, Shinde Sena and MNS
- Put up a credible performance in the local body polls due early next year
- Mount a challenge in the assembly in the absence of a leader of the opposition
- Secure the political future of their chosen heirs—Aaditya in Uddhav's case and Supriya in Pawar Sr's

COLOURED SAFFRON

The Mahayuti defied farmer distress, Maratha disaffection and the ignominy of the LS results to sweep Maharashtra



Though the Maratha threat failed to dent Mahayuti's chances, their demands cannot be ignored as that could trigger fresh agitations

While Uddhav would stay holed up in his personal residence Matoshree or the official residence Varsha, Shinde opened up access to the chief minister's bungalow.

That said, the party is in no mood to allow Shinde to grow further. He claims to be the true ideological inheritor of the old Sena; thus, as pro-Hindutva forces, they compete for the same political space in Maharashtra. Shinde's growth as a new Hindu Hriday Samrat or Marathi Hriday Samrat can only eat into the BJP's base, especially as it still searches for a comparable figure. As a senior official notes, the BJP will "not demolish one Uddhav Thackeray to replace him with another".

Ajit Pawar remains another power centre. From being perceived as the spare tyre in the alliance and written off after winning just one out of the four Lok Sabha seats his NCP contested, with wife Sunetra losing to cousin Supriya Sule from Baramati, Ajit's turnaround is one of the big stories of this election. No one had expected him to pull one over uncle Sharad Pawar. Stung by the Lok Sabha loss, the prodigal nephew had approached DesignBoxed chief Naresh Arora for an image makeover, of attire as well as demeanour. Hence the sudden profusion of pink in his wardrobe, a smiling visage to replace the grimness of yore. The near-total transfer of BJP and Sena votes to his nominees did no harm either. He was also careful not to attack Pawar Sr directly, and even admitted that fielding wife Sunetra against his cousin Supriya was a mistake. "Politics shouldn't be allowed to enter homes," he conceded. The BJP will have to earmark a few prize portfolios for him, even though his loyalty isn't in doubt: an NCP reunion seems unlikely for now after Pawar Sr returned the compliment, fielding Ajit's nephew Yugendra against him in Baramati.

The Promises and the Perils

The political challenges apart, the new dispensation will also have to grapple with the weight of its election promises. The Rs 46,000 crore Ladki Bahin Yojana, under which women from economically weaker sections were entitled to a monthly dole of Rs 1,500, was unequivo-